

CALIMESA FIRE DEPARTMENT

POLICY MANUAL

VOLUME 6

Policy: 600.09 Water Rescue Operations

11/2023

Page 1 of 5

This policy establishes a standard structure and procedure for all fire department personnel operating at incidents involving water rescue operations. The policy outlines responsibilities for first-responders, Command Officers and other fire department personnel responding to such incidents.

PURPOSE

The purpose of this procedure is to establish guidelines for the response of fire department personnel and equipment to water rescue incidents. Because water rescue operations present a significant danger to fire department personnel, the safe and effective management of these operations require special considerations. This guideline identifies some of the critical issues that must be included in managing these incidents.

TACTICAL CONSIDERATIONS

Due to the inherent dangers associated with these operations, the Calimesa Fire Department Risk Management Profile shall be applied to all water rescue operations and shall be continuously reassessed throughout the incident. A phased approach to water rescue operations that include; Arrival, Pre-Rescue Operations, Rescue Operations and Termination can be utilized to safely and effectively mitigate these high-risk/low-frequency events.

PHASE I: ARRIVAL

A. ESTABLISH COMMAND

1. First arriving company officer shall assume Command and begin an immediate size-up of the situation.
2. First arriving Engine that is staffed with a Company Officer should be assigned Rescue Operations. The Company Officer assigned as the Rescue Operative should remain with his crew. Rescue Operations responsibilities include:
 - a. Assuming technical rescue operations control.
 - b. Identifying hazards and critical factors.
 - c. Developing a rescue plan and back-up plan.
 - d. Informing Command of conditions, actions, and needs during all phases of the Rescue Operation.
3. Designate a Safety Officer.

CALIMESA FIRE DEPARTMENT

POLICY MANUAL

VOLUME 6

Policy: 600.09 Water Rescue Operations

11/2023

Page 2 of 5

B. SIZE-UP

1. Secure a witness to assist in gathering information to determine exactly what happened and the location of any victim(s). If no witnesses are present, Command may have to look for clues on the scene to determine what happened.
2. Assess the immediate and potential hazards to the rescuers.
3. Isolate immediate hazard area, secure the scene, and deny entry for all non-rescue personnel.
4. Assess on-scene capabilities and determine the need for additional resources.

PHASE II: PRE-RESCUE OPERATIONS

It must be determined if this will be a RESCUE operation or a RECOVERY operation based on the survivability profile of the victim(s) which include factors such as the location and condition of the victim(s), and elapsed time since the accident occurred.

A. MAKE THE GENERAL AREA SAFE

1. Establish a hazard zone perimeter.
2. Keep all non-essential rescue personnel out of the hazard zone.
3. Remove all non-essential civilian personnel at least 150 feet away from the hazard zone.

B. MAKE THE RESCUE AREA SAFE

All personnel operating at or near the water shall be in proper personal protective equipment (PPE) that will include at a minimum: personal flotation device (PFD), approved water rescue helmet, and approved footwear.

1. Identify hazards that are present which include but are not limited to:
 - a. The volume of water.
 - b. The velocity of the water.
 - c. Debris in the water.
 - d. Hydraulics.
 - e. Depth of the water – rising / falling.
2. Assign personnel upstream.
 - a. Rescue personnel shall be assigned upstream to advise of any upstream hazards that may effect the rescue operations
3. Assign personnel downstream.

CALIMESA FIRE DEPARTMENT

POLICY MANUAL

VOLUME 6

Policy: 600.09 Water Rescue Operations

11/2023

Page 3 of 5

- a. Rescue personnel shall be assigned downstream with throw bags to capture rescue personnel or victim(s) that may be washed downstream.
4. Assemble all necessary personnel, equipment, and patient packaging equipment that will be required for the rescue operation.

PHASE III: RESCUE OPERATIONS

A. RESCUE SECTOR

1. Rescue responsibilities shall include the following:
 - a. Ensure that all personnel operating in the rescue are accounted for and wearing appropriate PPE.
 - b. Develop a rescue plan and a back-up plan.
 - c. Ensure the plan and back-up plan, which include emergency procedures, are communicated to all personnel operating on the incident.

B. THE RESCUE PLAN

Rescue operations should be conducted with as little risk to the rescuers as necessary to affect the rescue. Low-risk operations may not always be possible but should be considered first. The order of rescue from low-risk to high-risk are:

1. *TALK* – if water is calm or slow moving try to talk the victim into self-rescue if possible.
2. *REACH* – extend an arm, pike pole, rescue hook, or any other such object to reach the victim and pull from the water.
3. *THROW* – attempt to throw the victim(s) a throw-bag rescue line or some other type of approved safety flotation device and “pendulum-belay” or “haul” the victim(s) to the bank.
4. *ROW* - If it is determined that a boat-based operation shall be utilized. Rescue Sector shall assign a company on the opposite bank to assist in establishing an anchor for an approved rope system.
5. *GO* - If it is not possible to row to the victim, the Company Officer or Incident Commander should consider putting a rescuer or rescuers in the water to reach the victim. This is a very high-risk operation and shall be conducted exclusively by trained TRT personnel. Prior to entering the water, rescue personnel shall be briefed on the plan, the back-up plan and emergency procedures. Rescue personnel shall never be attached to a lifeline without the benefit of a quick-release mechanism approved for water rescue.

CALIMESA FIRE DEPARTMENT

POLICY MANUAL

VOLUME 6

Policy: 600.09 Water Rescue Operations

11/2023

Page 4 of 5

Rescue personnel shall never do a “breath-hold” surface dive in an attempt to locate a victim beneath the surface of the water.

6. *HELO* - Helicopter operations are considered high-risk and shall be decided upon through consultation with Safety Command and the Technical Advisor.

C. ASSESS THE VICTIM

When the rescuers reach the victim a primary survey shall be completed. If the victim is conscious rescuers should determine if the victim can assist in the rescue. If the victim is unconscious the rescue must be completed as quickly as possible.

D. TREATMENT

1. Initiate C-spine precautions as soon as possible.
2. Conduct a secondary survey and correct any life threatening conditions.
3. Provide for ALS level treatment and transportation to a hospital as indicated.

PHASE IV: TERMINATION

- A. Ensure personnel accountability.
- B. Consider decontamination of victim(s) and rescuer(s).
- C. Recover all tools and equipment used in the rescue/recovery. In cases of a fatality consider leaving everything in place until the investigative process has been completed.
- D. Consider a Post Incident Critique (may be more appropriate at a later date).
- E. Return to service after returning all equipment to apparatus.

ADDITIONAL CONSIDERATIONS

I. COMMAND STRUCTURE

- A. The first arriving unit shall assume Command of the incident. This unit shall remain in Command until Command is transferred to improve the quality of the Command organization.

CALIMESA FIRE DEPARTMENT

POLICY MANUAL

VOLUME 6

Policy: 600.09 Water Rescue Operations

11/2023

Page 5 of 5

- B. The first arriving Company Officer should be assigned Rescue. Rescue teams, Upstream, Downstream, and any other such functional team operating near the water shall be under the direction of the Incident Commander

II. OTHER CONSIDERATIONS

- A. Consider the effects of inclement weather and water conditions on the hazard profile, the victim(s), and the rescuers with particular attention to the effects of hypothermia.
- B. Water rescue incidents attract the news media; consider assigning a PIO.